

DON'T SWEAT THE DETAILS

A Science Play

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CAST OF CHARACTERS

JORDAN, a New York-based exercise physiologist in their late 20s

BROOKE, a Michigan-based geomorphologist in their late 20s

The roles are open to any gender identity

TIME

Present-Day Summertime

SETTING

Bruce Trail in Bruce Peninsula National Park, Ontario

SYNOPSIS

"To sweat the details" is to worry about minor things. Hiking alongside physiologist Jordan, Brooke revisits an escarpment, the site of an accident that made them the geologist they are.

RESOURCES

Benson, Rebecca, and Paul von Hippel. "Obesity and the Natural Environment across US Counties." *American Journal of Public Health*, vol. 104, no. 7, 2014, pp. 1287-1293.,
<https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC4056217/>

Miller, John P., and Robert Scholten. *Laboratory Studies in Geology*. Freeman, 1966.

BRUCE PENINSULA NATIONAL PARK

The stage is a sunny nature trail.
Its edge is an escarpment.

JORDAN enters, holding a map. They
hike upstage.

BROOKE exhaustedly trails JORDAN.

BROOKE

The devil is in the details.

JORDAN

Hell yeah, this map sure is full of devils.
Sweat it out. It's good that you're hydrated.

BROOKE

Yes. I wasn't the last time I was here.

JORDAN

The park's sixty square miles. Was it near this
spot where it all went down? Where's the cliff?

BROOKE

I don't recall much of Bruce Peninsula at all,
but the press does remember I almost went down.

JORDAN

What you *did* risking your life is no pressing
matter. What you'll *do* with your life will
press on.

BROOKE

Sure. So, any news coming out of New York?

JORDAN

Nothing much. Actually, Savanna finished
kindergarten with career day where I showed her
class the things I do with my life.

BROOKE

Get them while they're young! Are you out there
getting kids interested in physiology?

JORDAN

Her gym teacher barely gets them to do jumping
jacks. Getting kids to understand their bodies
is a bit of a stretch. Did you stretch at all?

BROOKE

Don't ask.

JORDAN

Well, we'll get our answer. Come on, we have a
ways to go.

JORDAN and BROOKE hike about.

JORDAN (CONT'D)

You know, Brooke, we could've hiked somewhere cool. Like a volcano.

BROOKE

Oh here we go again...

JORDAN

Remember that video of Savanna's teacher and a model volcano, and the joy on my kid's face. You'd be her hero if you got into volcanoes!

BROOKE

Savanna's not into sand dunes? When she reaches high school, share my papers with her in the American Geophysical Union Advances.

JORDAN

Your love of sand will always be unexplainable.

BROOKE

You two can visit one. There's... I don't know New York ones on the top of my head.

JORDAN

I've visited some. You heard of Fire Island?

BROOKE

That's how my legs feel right now. On fire.

JORDAN

You should've stretched. Everything stretches. Animals, plants, land... I'm sure rocks do. Does the Earth stretch their layers?

BROOKE

Their crust constantly stretches with tectonic tension. Like our conversation and this hike!

JORDAN

It's your *fault* you're the best geomorphologist I know. A leg up for the coolest job title.

BROOKE

Thanks?

JORDAN (CONT'D)

But nothing quite as *hot* as a volcanologist's.

BROOKE (CONT'D)

Most volcanologists end up not on the field but in the labs which are air-conditioned.

JORDAN

We have a ways to go in conditioning you to feel light as air like nothing else matters.

JORDAN and BROOKE stay put.

JORDAN (CONT'D)
Things have been heavy lately.

BROOKE
Jordan. You can tell me anything.

JORDAN
It's my body...

BROOKE JORDAN (CONT'D)
Did you have a bad doctor's I'm regaining weight.
appointment?

BROOKE (CONT'D)
Your old body's coming back? Congrats!

JORDAN
Stop. I'm getting bad eyeballs online.

BROOKE
Look, we'll go on more hikes together. It's
good to lay off social media every so often.
Ignore those negative comments. The internet
has unhealthy body standards.

JORDAN
Yeah, I don't wanna see another post about your
mocktails with your weirdass partner.

BROOKE
I need to be with my Celestine, the finest
Astronomy on Tap host. Plus, there's nothing to
do in UrbanBeat or Lansing.

JORDAN
Does Lansing host a marathon?

BROOKE
The River Run I think is half. There are full
ones throughout Michigan, like Grand Rapids.

JORDAN
You should be used to this sorta landscape.
It's virtually the same Great Lakes climate.

BROOKE
Sure, Pleistocene glaciers carved lands we walk
on. I appreciate our great bodies of water,
much like how you should appreciate your body-

JORDAN
Humanity has a ways to go when it comes to
carving trails for themselves...

The clouds engulf the Sun.

JORDAN (CONT'D)

Hopefully, it doesn't start downpouring.

BROOKE

The world's sweating. Rain is good for us all.

JORDAN

Based on the NIH, obesity is prevalent in places with dark or overcast weather patterns.

BROOKE

You were a rock.

JORDAN

I weighed as much as he does. BROOKE (CONT'D)
A porous rock.

JORDAN (CONT'D)

He's most certainly a BROOKE (CONT'D)
billionaire by now. No. You were like a
sandstone.

JORDAN (CONT'D)

Ya head's in the sand again! BROOKE (CONT'D)
Pumice then. Volcanic rocks.

BROOKE (CONT'D)

Immense porosity- For these holes inside you,
you filled it with matrices containing clay and
micas. They were what held you, an unconfined
aquifer, together, but all you saw was this
groundwater you're holding-

JORDAN

Ugh, water weight. BROOKE (CONT'D)
You said hydration was good!

BROOKE (CONT'D)

And now you're losing yourself.

JORDAN

I'm not anorexic. BROOKE (CONT'D)
I'm saying you've changed.

JORDAN (CONT'D)

*I'll speak your language as a former rock. I am
permeable? So water moves in and out of me.
They take away my old features and fresh water
grants me new details. Same is done in other
natural systems. Matrices in eukaryotic cells.
During cytokinesis, they clone... Oh.*

BROOKE

So cells stay identical and keep their details?

JORDAN

Forget it. I lost track of my thoughts much
like we lost track of where we're going. This
map is Hell. We have no ways to go!

JORDAN crumples the map, then almost puts it in their mouth before tossing it away.

JORDAN (CONT'D)

This hike was for *your* sake!

BROOKE

I'm grateful. But I have thick skin. I got to.

JORDAN

You are as superficial as the stratum corneum. The surface layer of the *epidermis*. Hey, that'd be a good name for a boat.

BROOKE

Your body is so foreboding.

JORDAN

My life is healthy and balanced. I drink tons of water. And my family is proud of the physiologist I grew up to be.

BROOKE

Your judgmental family holds
no water. Savanna is fine.

JORDAN (CONT'D)

They are not judgmental!

BROOKE (CONT'D)

Balance is like groundwater. There is a zone of aeration and saturation. Air is running in your pores and water is running out of them.

JORDAN

My skin has so much room to breathe that it feels the breeze. Brrr... My mind is at ease.

BROOKE

Then you wouldn't mind telling me why your body has been in uncanny valley.

JORDAN

Uncanny?! You knew my goal has been to get slim since we left Northern. Michigan is the space to focus on schooling, but I can achieve anything in New York. I've been in very open-minded circles who know what's best for their bodies while I had Savanna.

BROOKE

You got fake friends who make your degree go to waste.

JORDAN

You got a ways to go when it comes to making friends.

BROOKE picks up the crumpled map.
They contort it based on their
cycle of erosion talk.

JORDAN (CONT'D)

What are you staging?

BROOKE

Your intervention. There are three stages in
the stream cycle of erosion: youth, maturity,
and old age.

JORDAN

Your field sure is analogous to our life cycle.

BROOKE

Geomorphologists do all we can to be relatable.
Can you categorize these valleys in this map?

JORDAN

I see the narrow wrinkle as youth, the widest
is old age, and in-betweens are like mature.

BROOKE

Spot on. The youth stage has irregular steep
gradients, no floodplains, and goes through
downcutting by eroding the riverbed. It gives
some valleys a V shape. Maturity has smooth
gradients, few waterfalls, and meanders. These
valleys are all about U, U-shaped. And old age
is the extreme, broader maturity stage.

JORDAN

Speaking of analogy: Letting go of minor things
get easier with time cause your valley's wider.
My body's "uncanny." Who cares? We are almost
in the maturity cycle. It's all about you.

BROOKE

I need to point out that each geologist
discerns stream cycles differently. Each stage
is necessarily transitional into the next, so
there are some degree of overlap in landform
characteristics which is to be expected.

JORDAN

It's like going from childhood to adolescence.
It's different for everybody! Even valleys have
liminal spaces.

BROOKE

"Liminal?"

JORDAN

Whenever my yoga instructor gets her ways to
go, she has us repeat...

JORDAN meditates. BROOKE follows.

JORDAN (CONT'D)

"A place where who we were ends and who we are begins."

BROOKE

And I'm here. Returning to the cliff that should have been my end...

JORDAN

The motorcycle accident did end you but only the bad parts of you. Parts of your quartz.

BROOKE

Granite?

JORDAN

Granted, I got into jewelry ever since my chubby fingers can fit a five and a half.

Alright, this five-and-a-half hour self-deprecating ends here. Let's get a move on.

BROOKE

So glad you've move on, *in the wrong direction.*

JORDAN (CONT'D)

Glad you now see it that way-
My path is righteous!

BROOKE (CONT'D)

This whole trail starts at Niagara Falls?

JORDAN

Five hundred miles. What you scientists say...

BROOKE

And Canadians here: eight hundred kilometers.

JORDAN

What else did Canada get wrong? The drinking age at eighteen years. It should be 118.

BROOKE

You're leaving me heated. Cut it out, Jordan!

JORDAN

Alcohol interferes with our brain's pathways to communicate, leaving us with no empathy, like a massasauga rattlesnake we bumped into earlier.

BROOKE

I shouldn't have been drinking poison at that age. Or cross the Ambassador Bridge into this country to get booze and party. I'm a V!

JORDAN

Sweat it all out. You have less of a ways to go-

BROOKE runs away from JORDAN.
BROOKE eventually finds the edge
of the stage, where they sit.

JORDAN (CONT'D)

Brooke! I'm sorry to open up old wounds! These are minor things. Dumb things you done as a minor. We've all done dumb things. You just got to release that water weight.

Brooke! Speaking like a rock: You're still a youthful stream cycle. Rigid gradient valley. You need to let the river rock your sides until it carves your valley into the shape of U.

Brooke. I admit I am rougher around the edges. I know you hoped I'd be the mature stream cycle. Yeah... Now I live in New York City, conflating self-respect with something else.

Brooke. You mean the world since Marquette. The body of the overweight freshman is gone, but my heart's still here. It's getting dark. Leaving me alone out here is so thin-skinned of you!

Brooke... I am getting thin-skinned. Even if I'm hydrated, I'm a rock with waterless pores. What you called: aeration. Maybe, I should go reexamine my health and gain the few pounds.

BROOKE

I'm surprised you haven't tried calling! Well, I'm proud you've got your mind off the phone for once in a long time. Aside from that, you're still full of hot air. Sweat that out!

JORDAN

Brooke... You know what...

Savanna is getting into astronomy, so we should head to the beach sometime with you and Celestine and introduce Savanna to some sand dunes before stargazing then! How's that sound?

BROOKE

You are out of this world... Fine. I'll stop burying my head in the sand.

JORDAN

Where are you?!

BROOKE

I'm not too far. Come! You'll enjoy the look of this body of water.

JORDAN

Before I ever do, I have a ways to go...

JORDAN reaches the escarpment.
They sit with BROOKE.

JORDAN (CONT'D)
Niagara Escarpment seems past old age stage.

BROOKE
At least three thousand years ago.

JORDAN
Are you getting past your high school phase?

BROOKE
Three thousand days ago...? Well, me and the other seniors had the time of our lives here. A few drinks. *A lot to drink.* Key in the ignition switch. My pop's motorcycle plummeting off this cliff. That one tree stopping me. Stupid teen-

JORDAN
And yet, you had a future ahead and didn't die-

BROOKE
The Bruce Peninsula Press contacted my school. General Motors Foundation took my engineering scholarship. And that humiliating graduation, almost non-graduation.

JORDAN
Anything beyond such minor details?

BROOKE
Nothing major.
I changed majors at our college that wasn't my choice. It took years before I returned to the beach; for my geology elective. Now I work for the Alliance for the Great Lakes. You happy?

JORDAN
You're sweating the big things!

BROOKE
I try to remind myself that there are bigger issues than irresponsible kids. Last time, there was a dune complex below. Lake Huron probably swallowed it. Earth is sweating... Anyways, it's a worry for everyday after today.
I still have a ways to go, Jordan. The memories erode me. But, I know over time things I did as a high schooler are less likely to kick up a storm.

JORDAN
Way to go, Brooke.

The clouds sweat.

JORDAN and BROOKE are in major perspiration.

JORDAN (CONT'D)

But before we hike back, Mother Nature can be a bit of a stretch...

BROOKE

Do ask.

JORDAN

Can you answer for the waves below?

BROOKE

Things from a minor wind to a major earthquake can help "Mother Nature" make waves. And years of weathering them made this the escarpment that they are. The devil is in their details.

END OF PLAY